

CUSA CUSA PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	WKU HILLTOPPERS
	2	LIBERTY FLAMES
	3	KENNESAW STATE OWLS
	4	JACKSONVILLE STATE GAMECOCKS
	5	DELAWARE BLUE HENS
	6	FIU PANTHERS
	7	MISSOURI STATE BEARS
	8	NEW MEXICO STATE AGGIES
	9	MIDDLE TENNESSEE BLUE RAIDERS
	10	SAM HOUSTON BEARKATS

CUSA CHAMPIONSHIP WKU OVER LIBERTY



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT
STEVEN LASSAN AT
ATHLONSports.com
FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND
THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-CUSA TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	NICK MINICUCCI	Delaware
RB	JO SILVER	Delaware
RB	ANTHONY CARRIE	FIU
AP	JMARIYAE ROBINSON	Missouri State
WR	K.D. HUTCHINSON	WKU
WR	SEAN WILSON	Delaware
WR	DEONDRE JOHNSON	Jacksonville State
TE	JERON ASKREN	Missouri State
C	STEVEN DEMBOSKI	Delaware
OL	AARON FENIMORE	Liberty
OL	LUCAS MRACHKOVSKIY	Jacksonville State
OL	D.J. GETH	Liberty
OL	MATEO GUEVARA	Kennesaw State

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	KENTON SIMMONS	FIU
DL	MIKE JARVIS	Liberty
DL	MARCUS PATTERSON	Kennesaw State
DL	JAWAUN CAMPBELL	Jacksonville State
LB	MAC SANDERS	Jacksonville State
LB	BARON HOPSON	Kennesaw State
LB	WALKER O'STEEN	Jacksonville State
LB	GAVIN MOUL	Delaware
DB	TRE'QUON FEGANS	Jacksonville State
DB	SHAMIR STERLIN	FIU
DB	CALEB NIX	Jacksonville State
DB	KT SEAY	Delaware

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	GARRISON RIPPA	Jacksonville State
P	ASHTON LOGAN	Middle Tennessee
KR	TIM BURNS JR.	Sam Houston
PR	MAGUIRE ANDERSON	FIU

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Salute to Veterans: Delaware vs. Georgia Southern

68 Ventures: Jacksonville State vs. Arkansas State

New Orleans: WKU vs. James Madison

Myrtle Beach: Liberty vs. Marshall

Independence: Kennesaw State vs. West Virginia

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

DELAWARE

Defense: New: Manny Rojas, Rocco DiMeco; Old: Manny Rojas

JACKSONVILLE STATE

Offense: New: Taylor Housewright
Old: Clint Trickett



NEWLAND ISAAC, LIBERTY

LIBERTY

Offense: New: Newland Isaac
Old: Willy Korn, Newland Isaac
Defense: New: Shawn Quinn
Old: Skylor Magee, Kyle Krantz

MIDDLE TENNESSEE

Offense: New: Anthony Scelfo
Old: Bodie Reeder

MISSOURI STATE

Offense: New: Mark Cala
Old: Nick Petrino
Defense: New: Jack Curtis
Old: L.D. Scott

WKU

Offense: New: Bodie Reeder, Joe Bernardi; Old: Rick Bowie
Defense: New: Davis Merritt
Old: Da'Von Brown, Davis Merritt

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Ryan Mallory	LB	Sam Houston	★★★	893
2. Jaeden McMillan	WR	FIU	★★★	968
3. Dominic Turnbull	CB	FIU	★★★	1,095
4. Ellis Alloway	LB	Liberty	★★★	1,110
5. Devin Hamilton	WR	WKU	★★★	1,130



NICK MINICUCCI, DELAWARE
K.D. HUTCHINSON, WKU



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	NEW SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. JJ Kohl	QB	FIU	Appalachian State
Kohl is a former blue-chip recruit with a big arm who came on strong late last season.			
2. Deshawn Purdie	QB	Liberty	Wake Forest
Now on his third school, Purdie has Power 4 experience and a knack for big plays.			
3. Rickie Collins	QB	Kennesaw State	Syracuse
Collins struggled in his first starting stint but could catch on with the Owls.			
4. Makai Jackson	WR	Liberty	Indiana
Jackson is a downfield threat who previously earned All-Sun Belt honors.			
5. Kam Davis	RB	Liberty	Florida State
Davis has the talent to be the Flames' next 1,000-yard rusher.			
6. James Jones	RB	New Mexico State	Delaware State
James is a home-run hitter who averaged just under 10 yards per carry last season.			
7. Triston Morgan	RB	Kennesaw State	Benedict
Morgan is making the jump from DII to DI on the heels of a breakout season.			
8. Nigel Johnson	WR	WKU	South Carolina State
Johnson brings field-stretching ability to round out the Hilltoppers' receiver room.			
9. Trey Hedden	QB	New Mexico State	Furman
A two-year starter for Furman, Hedden was among the most accurate QBs in the FCS.			
10. Henry Belin IV	QB	Missouri State	Duke
Belin has Power 4 starting experience and profiles as a dual-threat for the Bears.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. WKU (74)	5. Liberty (118)	9. Missouri State (130)
2. Jacksonville State (84)	6. Middle Tennessee (120)	10. New Mexico State (139)
3. FIU (101)	7. Sam Houston (122)	
4. Delaware (112)	8. Kennesaw State (129)	

*Rankings per Rivals;
National ranking in parentheses*

GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 5 Liberty at James Madison	Nov. 7 Delaware at Kennesaw State
Oct. 2 Liberty at Delaware	Nov. 14 Jacksonville State at WKU
Oct. 7 Jacksonville St. at Kennesaw St.	Nov. 14 FIU at Delaware
Oct. 13 FIU at Jacksonville State	Nov. 21 WKU at Liberty
Oct. 21 Liberty at Kennesaw State	Nov. 28 Kennesaw State at WKU
Nov. 7 WKU at Middle Tennessee	Nov. 28 Jacksonville State at Delaware

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Tristan Lyles	EDGE	Jacksonville St.	★★★	1,152
7. Bryson Maddox	WR	MTSU	★★★	1,156
8. Jakobe Dejesus	WR	Liberty	★★★	1,216
9. Malcolm Gaston	IOL	Liberty	★★★	1,237
10. Xavier Rucker	RB	New Mexico St.	★★★	1,258

Rankings per Rivals industry ranking;



DELAWARE BLUE HENS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 107 | CUSA PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 CUSA

OFFENSE In their first year at the FBS level, the Blue Hens led Conference USA in total offense and passing offense and were second in points per game in 2025. Quarterback Nick Minicucci successfully orchestrated head coach Ryan Carty's spread offense, and he returns after earning second-team All-CUSA status and leading the league in passing yards (3,683) and total offense (3,918). He also rushed for 10 TDs.

The Blue Hens did lose the two best players on their offensive front with Fintan Brose's graduation and Anwar O'neal's transfer to Louisville. But all-league center Steven Demboski is a solid anchor for what should still be a strong offensive line.

The Blue Hens return their top four rushers, led by Jo Silver, while adding a versatile transfer in Kaderris Roberts from Bowling Green. Leading receiver Sean Wilson (68 catches for 877 yards and three TDs) is also back, along with the reliable Donovan Lewis, speedy Nick Tyree and several promising transfer additions.

DEFENSE Delaware ranked among CUSA's worst in points, total yards and passing yards allowed last year. The Hens were way too susceptible to allowing explosive third- and fourth-down plays and aim to improve in that area this year, as well as in forcing turnovers.

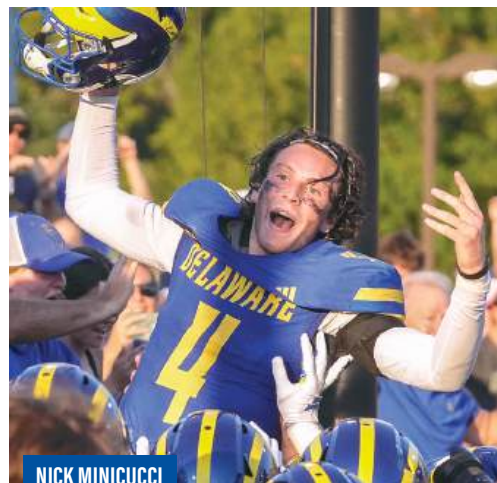
In safety KT Seay, a first-team All-CUSA choice, they return their best defensive player, one who can cover ground and deliver a hit or snare a takeaway. Inside linebacker Gavin Moul, third in CUSA in tackles last year, is also a proven stopper.

Up front, Delaware will be looking for Noah Matthews, in his second UD season, to exhibit the playmaking ability that landed him at Kentucky to start his college career. Cornerback Jamarion Kolagbodi was the secondary's most accomplished freshman last year, and the Hens will look for contributions from newcomers such as George Mullins from Michigan State and Jaquise Alexander from North Dakota State.

SPECIALISTS Second-team All-CUSA kicker Nate Reed will be tough to replace, with Div. III Salisbury transfer Tucker Smack and freshman Kason Mullis competing for that key role. Punter Josh Cupitt returns after missing 2025 with a knee injury and has proven reliable in the past. Delaware has a slew of potentially explosive return candidates.

FINAL ANALYSIS Delaware was better than most expected while going 4-4 in Conference USA and 7-6 overall in its debut FBS season, capped by its 20-13 68 Ventures Bowl win over Louisiana. Now eligible for the first time to play for the Conference USA title, Delaware — and its ardent followers — will expect to be in championship contention this year.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	Delaware State	W	35-17	Sept. 3	Merrimack	1. Carson Griffin, ATH	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Colorado	L	7-31	Sept. 12	at Vanderbilt	2. Tyler Bell, QB	★★★★
Sept. 13	UConn (ot)	W	44-41	Sept. 19	Coastal Carolina	3. Trenton Gummer, CB	★★★★
Sept. 20	at FIU	W	38-16	Sept. 26	at Virginia	4. Cristian Alvarez, IOL	★★★★
Oct. 3	WKU	L	24-27	Oct. 2	Liberty	5. Jaiden Edwards, IOL	★★★★
Oct. 15	at Jacksonville State	L	25-38	Oct. 13	at Middle Tenn.	6. Tae'Sean Robinson, WR	★★★★
Oct. 22	Middle Tennessee	W	31-28	Oct. 20	Missouri State	7. Kevin Moore, S	★★★★
Nov. 1	at Liberty	L	30-59	Oct. 27	at WKU	8. Dannel Jester, S	★★★★
Nov. 8	Louisiana Tech	W	25-24	Nov. 7	at Kennesaw State	9. Dorian Rutledge, S	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Sam Houston	L	23-26	Nov. 14	FIU	10. Demarco Daniels, LB	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Wake Forest	L	14-52	Nov. 21	at New Mexico State	*Per Rivals	
Nov. 29	UTEP	W	61-31	Nov. 28	Jacksonville State		
Dec. 17	vs. Louisiana #	W	20-13				
#68 Ventures Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Ryan Carty • Record at School: 33-17 (4 years)			
				Career Record: 33-17 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Terence Archer			
				Defensive Coordinators: Manny Rojas, Rocco DiMeo			
				Location: Newark, Del. • Stadium: Delaware Stadium (18,500)			



NICK MINICUCCI

SCOUTING THE BLUE HENS

"What stands out to me is that they return pretty much their whole team. They were fortunate enough to keep three or four of their starting O-linemen, a couple of their receivers, their quarterback, both running backs — even defensively, they were able to keep most of that unit, then they went and added really good players in the portal. ... I think that they're the team to beat in our conference. Just what they were able to do offensively and defensively in that transition to our conference, keeping that team together for a second year, I think they're gonna be a really fric-kin' good football team. They've got some money to work with, but I just think it goes back to the buy-in from that team. They've got a bunch of guys who put their heart and soul into it."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	18	SEAN WILSON (SO.)	0	Bryson Graves* (Jr.)
WR	6	Nick Tyree (So.)	1	Brandon Rehmann (So.)
WR	14	Donovan Lewis (Jr.)	17	Emmanuel Doku (Fr.)
LT	75	NOAH ROSAHAC (SO.)	65	Wahkeem Roman (Sr.)
LG	67	Mustafa Feika* (Jr.)	74	Tyler Burnham (So.)
C	61	STEVEN DEMBOSKI (SR.)	59	Patrick Methlie (Sr.)
RG	51	Chandler Telfaire (Fr.)	78	Bentley Allen II (Fr.)
RT	62	ANTHONY CACCESE (JR.)	60	Carter Sareyka (So.)
TE	88	ELIJAH SESSOMS (SR.)	40	Scott Moore (Fr.)
QB	4	NICK MINICUCCI (JR.)	16	Braden Streeter (So.)
RB	27	JO SILVER (SR.)	21	Viron Ellison Jr. (So.)

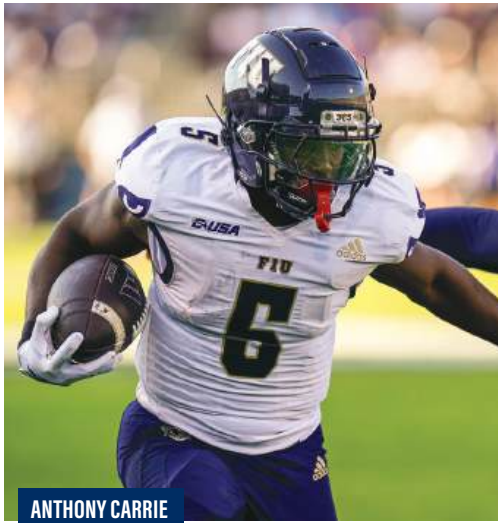
DEFENSE (5)

DL	13	NOAH MATTHEWS (SR.)	0	Q'yaier Price (Sr.)
DL	52	Dominick Brogna (Sr.)	33	Trace Scott III (So.)
DL	44	Kaeden Singleton (So.)	89	Nate Ray (Jr.)
LB	9	Colin Gallagher (So.)	46	Julius Puryear (Fr.)
MLB	35	GAVIN MOUL (JR.)	11	Jawarren Corbin (Jr.)
LB	10	BLAKE MATTHEWS (SR.)	20	Jalen Bell* (Jr.)
CB	18	Jamarion Kolagbodi (Fr.)	24	Jalen Ross (Fr.)
CB	6	KSHAWN COX JR. (JR.)	8	Jaquise Alexander* (Jr.)
S	7	KT SEAY (JR.)	27	AJ Graham (Fr.)
S	2	Kahlil Ali (Jr.)	36	Nasir Eatmon (Fr.)
S	29	George Mullins* (Fr.)	16	Noah Jefferson (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	31	Tucker Smack* (Jr.)	KR	1	Brandon Rehmann (So.)
P	39	Josh Cupitt (Sr.)	PR	0	Bryson Graves* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ANTHONY CARRIE

SCOUTING THE PANTHERS

"They've got two guys who played behind [2025 leading rusher Kejon Owens] and played a decent amount last year who should be able to step in. They've got Anthony Carrie, who transferred last year from Georgia Tech. He's a solid football player. ... Those dudes play hard as s—. They're athletic. They're Florida creatures, as we call them. They're just long, big-bodied people. Those dudes are hard to get around. Those defensive backs are super long, so they're hard to win against. I think that they're going to be really good under [head coach] Willie Simmons. He's done a damn good job recruiting and building up that team so far."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	2	Maguire Anderson (Jr.)	8	Greg Gaines III* (Sr.)
WR	0	Jojo Stone (So.)	13	Tyson Carter (So.)
WR	7	KYLE MCNEAL (JR.)	6	Eric Nelson (So.)
LT	50	Jeremy Smith (Fr.)	58	Oscar Colon* (Sr.)
LG	71	Antonio Tripp Jr. (Jr.)	56	Marc Michel Jr. (Fr.)
C	55	Daveion Harley* (Jr.)	67	Jon Rodriguez (So.)
RG	54	Zaire Flournoy (Sr.)	73	Spencer Webb (Sr.)
RT	51	Manasseh Ripert* (Sr.)	58	Oscar Colon* (Sr.)
TE	88	Kevin Schaeffer* (Sr.)	9	Jackson Verdugo (So.)
QB	17	JJ Kohl* (Jr.)	11	Zach Marker* (Sr.)
RB	1	Anthony Carrie (Jr.)	3	Devonte Lyons (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	5	KENTON SIMMONS (SR.)	14	Robert Williams (So.)
DT	99	Germaine Carter (Jr.)	88	Elijah Simmons* (Sr.)
DT	15	Nathan Jennings* (Fr.)	12	RJ Moss Jr.* (So.)
DE	13	Dante Anderson (Sr.)	45	Lamont Green Jr. (Jr.)
MLB	9	JOSHIAH TAYLOR (JR.)	22	Brayshawn Littlejohn* (Jr.)
WLB	11	Percy Courtney Jr. (Sr.)	18	JaCorey "Pickle" Stewart* (So.)
CB	0	Da'Vontae Floyd* (So.)	6	Lawrence Johnson* (Jr.)
CB	7	Jai-Ayviaunyn Celestine (Sr.)	8	Ryan Gadson* (Jr.)
NB	2	DeAndre Boykins* (Sr.)	21	Karaijus Hayes (Fr.)
S	3	Demetrius Hill (Sr.)	4	Wesley Miller* (Sr.)
S	1	SHAMIR STERLIN (SO.)	27	Eric Johnson (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	48	Robert Czeremcha (So.)	KR	3	Devonte Lyons (So.)
P	41	Stone Springman (Jr.)	PR	2	Maguire Anderson (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



FIU PANTHERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 112 | CUSA PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 5-3 CUSA

OFFENSE The Panthers have undergone a lot of turnover. Quarterback Keyone Jenkins left for UCF via the transfer portal, and head coach Willie Simmons replaced Jenkins with transfer JJ Kohl. At 6-foot-7 and 250 pounds, Kohl is larger than most quarterbacks, and he is coming off a solid 2025 performance at Appalachian State, completing 61.6% of his passes for 1,465 yards, 12 touchdowns and only two interceptions.

Kejon Owens departed for the pro ranks following a 1,300-yard season, but the Panthers return their No. 2 rusher, Anthony Carrie (469 yards, five touchdowns last year). FIU also returns wide receivers Kyle McNeal, Maguire Anderson and Jojo Stone, and the Panthers added Greg Gaines III, a 1,000-yard receiver at FCS Rhode Island.

FIU lost all five offensive line starters and will rely on returnees Zaire Flournoy and Antonio Tripp Jr. to anchor the unit.

DEFENSE Defensive end Kenton Simmons returns after a strong 2025 campaign in which he posted eight tackles for a loss and six sacks, earning second-team All-CUSA honors. Dante Anderson, who had three sacks last season, also returns to the edge. Germaine Carter, who had 19 tackles and 1.5 sacks, will play a key role at defensive tackle, and West Virginia transfer Elijah Simmons will factor in as well.

Sophomore middle linebacker Josiah Taylor is the leading returning tackler, having racked up 76 stops with 6.5 for a loss and two sacks in 2025. Percy Courtney Jr. returns as the weakside linebacker after finishing third on the team with seven tackles for a loss.

Defensive back Shamir Sterlin, a Freshman All-CUSA performer last year, returns after making 65 tackles. The secondary also boasts safety Demetrius Hill, nickel DeAndre Boykins and corners Da'Vontae Floyd, Jai-Ayviaunyn Celestine and Lawrence Johnson.

SPECIALISTS Robert Czeremcha is poised to take over placekicking duties after making 2-of-3 attempts last year. Former Miami (Fla.) transfer Stone Springman is slated to be the punter, and Devonte Lyons and Maguire Anderson will be the main return men. Anderson had a 97-yard punt-return touchdown against UTSA in the First Responder Bowl.

FINAL ANALYSIS FIU took a big step forward in its first year with Simmons at the helm, notching the program's first winning season since 2018 and first bowl appearance since 2019, boosting the team's confidence and proving to the players that the Panthers can taste success. But the departure of several key contributors due to graduation or transfer means that the Panthers will have to rely on newcomers to keep the program moving in the right direction.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 5-3 CUSA)

Aug. 29	Bethune-Cookman	W	42-9
Sept. 6	at Penn State	L	0-34
Sept. 13	Florida Atlantic	W	38-28
Sept. 20	Delaware	L	16-38
Oct. 4	at UConn	L	10-51
Oct. 14	at WKU	W	25-6
Oct. 21	Kennesaw State	L	26-45
Oct. 29	at Missouri State	L	21-28
Nov. 8	at Middle Tennessee	W	56-30
Nov. 15	Liberty (ot)	W	34-27
Nov. 22	Jacksonville State	W	27-21
Nov. 29	at Sam Houston	W	56-16
Dec. 26	vs. UTSA #	L	20-57

#First Responder Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at South Florida
Sept. 12	Buffalo
Sept. 19	at Florida Atlantic
Sept. 26	Long Island
Oct. 7	New Mexico State
Oct. 13	at Jacksonville State
Oct. 20	Middle Tennessee
Oct. 31	at Liberty
Nov. 7	Missouri State
Nov. 14	at Delaware
Nov. 21	at Kennesaw State
Nov. 28	Sam Houston

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Dominic Turnbull, CB	★★★★
2.	Jaeden McMillan, WR	★★★★
3.	James Resar, TE	★★★★
4.	Karaijus Hayes, S	★★★★
5.	Malik Penson, WR	★★★★
6.	Michael Smarts, EDGE	★★★★
7.	Barrett Schulz, WR	★★★★
8.	Zay West, CB	★★★★
9.	Riley Wilson, OT	★★★★
10.	Justin Compere, RB	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Willie Simmons • Record at School: 7-6 (1 year)
Career Record: 73-30 (9 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Nick Coleman
Defensive Coordinator: Jovan Dewitt • Location: University Park, Fla.
Stadium: Pitbull Stadium (20,000)



JACKSONVILLE STATE GAMECOCKS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 106 | CUSA PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 9-5, 7-1 CUSA

OFFENSE Year 2 under head coach Charles Kelly will feature many familiar faces, although the offense transitions to first-year coordinator Taylor Housewright. Dual-threat quarterback Caden Creel returns after throwing for 1,514 yards and running for 1,075 last season, with 16 total touchdowns. Redshirt freshman Jack Moran is likely to serve as the backup.

The running back room will lose Conference USA MVP Cam Cook, but it still has depth in Justus Savage, Andrew Paul, Khristian Lando, Jalen Likely and Lucas Farrington. The offensive line features experienced returnees Jeremiah Orr, Lance Johnson and Lucas Mrachkovskiy.

Leading receiver Deondre Johnson, who had 30 catches for 724 yards and six touchdowns and stands 6-foot-8, returns alongside Dylan Gentry, Franklin Baret Jr. and Gabe Glover. Missouri State transfer Ronnel Johnson (463 yards, two touchdowns) and FCS Murray State transfer Darius Cannon (737 yards, three touchdowns) are also expected to be involved.

DEFENSE Despite some departures, the defense has a solid core returning. Cornerbacks Tre'Quon Fegans and Jaheim Jenkins had strong seasons, with first-team All-CUSA safety Caleb Nix also back after recording four interceptions and three fumble recoveries in 2025.

Leading tackler Mac Sanders returns after recording 85 total stops and a team-high 11.5 tackles for a loss as a freshman. Fellow linebacker Walker O'Steen, who ranked second on the team with 84 tackles, will line up alongside Ian Mitchell and Myles Butler.

The Gamecocks took a hit on the defensive line, losing their two sack leaders, and will turn to returnees Khurtiss Perry (21 tackles, 4.5 tackles for a loss), Gharin Stansbury (six quarterback hurries, five tackles for a loss) and Jawaun Campbell (22 tackles). Wisconsin transfer Angel Toombs is also likely to find a spot in the rotation up front.

SPECIALISTS Jax State's special teams unit returns first-team All-CUSA kicker Garrison Rippa, who went 40-for-40 on extra points and had a season-long field goal of 52 yards last season, and starting punter Conor Donaghy. A native of Ireland, Donaghy averaged 39.6 yards per punt last season. Cannon and Gentry are among Jax State's options on returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS The roster returns a strong core group and has made some solid additions via the transfer portal. Establishing a run game alongside Creel at quarterback will be the biggest key entering 2026 under a new offensive coordinator. The Gamecocks have played for a CUSA championship in each of the past two seasons — winning one — and made three straight bowl appearances, proving they belong in the CUSA conversation on a consistent basis. This season looks to be no different.

2025 RESULTS (9-5, 7-1 CUSA)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 28 at UCF L 10-17	Aug. 29 at North Dakota St.	1. Brayden Matthews, LB ★★★
Sept. 6 Liberty W 34-24	Sept. 5 Eastern Kentucky	2. Maurice Winston, RB ★★★
Sept. 13 at Georgia Southern L 34-41	Sept. 12 at Ohio	3. JT Howell, IOL ★★★
Sept. 20 Murray State W 45-10	Sept. 19 Georgia Southern	4. Andrew Smith, EDGE ★★★
Sept. 27 at Southern Miss L 25-42	Sept. 26 Middle Tennessee	5. Cedric Kouemi, RB ★★★
Oct. 9 at Sam Houston W 29-27	Oct. 7 at Kennesaw State	6. Jermaine Waters Jr., EDGE ★★★
Oct. 15 Delaware W 38-25	Oct. 13 FIU	7. Donovan Moorhead, QB ★★★
Oct. 29 at Middle Tennessee W 24-21	Oct. 28 at New Mexico State	8. Noah Lee, QB ★★★
Nov. 8 at UTEP W 30-27	Nov. 7 Sam Houston	9. Rodarion Jones, CB ★★★
Nov. 15 Kennesaw State W 35-26	Nov. 14 at WKU	10. Javan Allison, CB ★★★
Nov. 22 at FIU L 21-27	Nov. 21 Missouri State	
Nov. 29 WKU W 37-34	Nov. 28 at Delaware	
Dec. 5 Kennesaw State # L 15-19		
Dec. 16 vs. Troy % W 17-13		
#C-USA Championship %Salute to Veterans Bowl		*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Charles Kelly • Record at School: 9-5 (1 year)		
Career Record: 9-5 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Taylor Housewright		
Defensive Coordinator: Brian Williams • Location: Jacksonville, Ala.		
Stadium: AmFirst Stadium (22,500)		



CADEN CREEL

SCOUTING THE GAMECOCKS

"I think it's gonna be a lot of the same with them. Fortunately for us, [running back Cam Cook] is gone, but [quarterback Caden Creel] is still there, and their leading receiver, Deondre Johnson, is still there. I thought one of the more interesting things they did was take a bunch of Division II guys in the portal. That's kind of where they hung their hat. It'll be interesting to see how those guys handle moving up. ... For the most part, they were able to keep a decent amount intact while replacing the departures with some productive guys. I think they're gonna end up being the same. Really similar football team to what they were last year, but they're gonna have to have some guys step up and fill some voids, especially on the D-line."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	11	Deondre Johnson (Jr.)	9	Ronnel Johnson* (Jr.)
WR	84	Franklin Baret Jr. (So.)	81	Gabe Glover (So.)
WR	5	Dylan Gentry (So.)	3	Darius Cannon* (So.)
LT	79	LANCE JOHNSON (SO.)	73	J.R. Jernigan (So.)
LG	56	Daylan Martin (So.)	65	Britin Witt* (Jr.)
C	50	LUCAS MRACHKOVSKIY (SO.)	63	Ryland Bragg (Fr.)
RG	55	Ryan Walker* (So.)	54	Markevian Blake (Fr.)
RT	70	Jeremiah Orr (Sr.)	74	Amarii Atchison* (So.)
TE	83	David Alpers III* (So.)	88	Kam Bell (Jr.)
QB	12	CADEN CREEL (JR.)	15	Jack Moran (Fr.)
RB	21	Justus Savage (So.)	0	Andrew Paul (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	91	Gharin Stansbury (Sr.)	36	Angel Toombs* (Jr.)
DT	44	Khurtiss Perry (Sr.)	96	Nii Addy* (So.)
DT	93	JAWAUN CAMPBELL (JR.)	16	Quay Hood (So.)
OLB	13	Jacob Cruz (Sr.)	4	Shane Payton Hodges (Jr.)
ILB	59	MAC SANDERS (SO.)	0	Myles Butler (Sr.)
ILB	40	WALKER O'STEEN (SR.)	53	Ian Mitchell (So.)
CB	3	TRE'QUON FEGANS (SR.)	10	RJ Rainer (So.)
CB	22	Jaheim Jenkins (Sr.)	9	Jonavan Carr* (So.)
HUSKY	5	Rob Billings IV* (So.)	6	Kaden Cook* (Fr.)
S	1	CALEB NIX (SR.)	25	Vernon Woodward III* (Fr.)
S	7	Marc Woods (So.)	27	Riggs Dunn (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	37	Garrison Rippa (Jr.)	KR	3	Darius Cannon* (So.)
P	87	Conor Donaghy (So.)	PR	3	Darius Cannon* (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TYWON CHRISTOPHER

SCOUTING THE OWLS

"[Quarterback Amari Odom] was a big part of why they flipped the script. I'm not gonna say that they had an easy schedule, but I definitely think that they got kind of lucky on that side of things. It all started with [Odom]. What he was able to do with his legs and his arm, he was hard to contain, hard to stop. It'll be interesting this year with [Syracuse transfer quarterback Rickie Collins]. ... Unfortunately for them, they lost pretty much their entire roster. We'll see if they flipped it, but it looks like they've got a good quarterback coming in, and if he can replicate what [Odom] did, I think that they'll be just fine."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	9	Davis Bryson (Sr.)	11	Brayden Munroe* (Sr.)
WR	13	Dylan Gary* (Jr.)	4	Zion Booker* (Sr.)
WR	15	Javon Rogers (Jr.)	0	Keon Davis* (Jr.)
LT	56	JADARIOUS LEE (SR.)	71	ZaMario Woodgett (Fr.)
LG	51	Mike Wallace Jr.* (So.)	56	JaDarius Lee (Sr.)
C	55	Mateo Guevara* (Sr.)	69	Chase Stevens (So.)
RG	75	Precious Ekeh* (Jr.)	66	Luke Duska* (Sr.)
RT	76	NIKOLA MILOVAC (JR.)	62	Darius Neals* (So.)
TE	19	Reed Jesiolowski* (Jr.)	88	Jamari Harrold (So.)
QB	1	Rickie Collins* (Jr.)	2	Landon Varnes* (So.)
RB	21	Triston Morgan* (Sr.)	6	Latrell Murrell* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	6	MARCUS PATTERSON (SR.)	55	Ugonna Nwoha (Sr.)
NT	96	Jaiden Grimes (Jr.)	92	Jackson Cooper (So.)
DT	15	Devin Morgan* (Sr.)	99	Nasir Smith (So.)
RUSH	14	Donovan Westmoreland (Jr.)	18	Josh Anglin* (Jr.)
MLB	44	BARON HOPSON (SR.)	11	TYWON CHRISTOPHER (SO.)
OLB	8	Corey Kelly* (Jr.)	31	Kai Russell* (Sr.)
CB	5	Tay'vion Lawson (So.)	3	Jecari Bryson* (Sr.)
CB	10	Ethan Tookes (Jr.)	7	Luke Evans* (Jr.)
NB	12	Kody Jones (Sr.)	2	Tony Williams Jr.* (Fr.)
S	4	Alexander Ford (Sr.)	20	TYLER HALLUM (SR.)
S	9	ISAAC PAUL (JR.)	13	Cam Miller* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	89	Daniel Kinney (Fr.)	KR	9	Davis Bryson (Sr.)
P	34	Matt McKenzie* (Sr.)	PR	4	Zion Booker* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



KENNESAW STATE OWLS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 105 | CUSA PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 10-4, 7-1 CUSA

OFFENSE KSU's high-octane attack tied for fourth in Conference USA in total offense (402.4 yards) last season. The Owls lost many of the key components of their attack, notably quarterback Amari Odom, who transferred to Syracuse, and wide receiver Gabe Benyard, who graduated. The quarterback job will fall to either Rickie Collins, who transferred from Syracuse, or Landon Varnes, who came in from Mississippi Gulf Coast CC. The pair emerged from spring practice essentially even.

The all-new crew of running backs is led by transfers Triston Morgan, who ran for 809 yards for Div. II playoff team Benedict, and Latrelle Murrell, who ran for 893 yards at FCS West Georgia. The similarly retooled receiver group features holdover Javon Rogers, who began to emerge in spring camp.

The offensive line will be bigger this year and features two holdovers in tackles JaDarius Lee and Nikola Milovac, with Middle Tennessee transfer Mateo Guevara coming off a dominant spring locked in at center.

DEFENSE The Owls allowed the fourth-fewest points (25.5) per game in CUSA and tied for first with 31 sacks, and they were able to hold onto important pieces of their defense.

Key returners include defensive end Marcus Patterson, rush end Donovan Westmoreland and middle linebacker Baron Hopson. Westmoreland, formerly at South Carolina, was finally healthy and recorded 37 tackles and four sacks. Team leader Hopson decided to return as a grad student after making 72 tackles (nine for a loss) and one interception.

The secondary returns nickel Kody Jones and athletic safety Isaac Paul, who came back after dipping a toe in the transfer portal.

SPECIALISTS Daniel Kinney is finally healthy after battling an undisclosed injury and will have the placekicking job to himself this year. He played four games and was 6-for-7 on field goals with a 50-yarder. Matt McKenzie is an Australian punter who appeared in six games last year for Arizona State, averaging 34.6 yards on 12 kicks.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Owls were one of the nation's biggest success stories last year, as new head coach Jerry Mack led the team to a 10-4 record, the Conference USA championship and the school's first bowl appearance. Mack was named CUSA Coach of the Year and the Bear Bryant National Newcomer Coach of the Year. It was only the fourth time a team has won 10 or more games in only its second season of FBS reclassification. The Owls won't be sneaking up on anyone this time, but they do host regular-season champion Jacksonville State in early October.

2025 RESULTS (10-4, 7-1 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	at Wake Forest	L	9-10	Sept. 3	West Georgia	1. Jeremiah Tabb, WR	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Indiana	L	9-56	Sept. 12	Georgia State	2. Landon Varnes, QB	★★★★
Sept. 13	Merrimack	W	27-13	Sept. 19	at Tennessee	3. Celley Davis, RB	★★★★
Sept. 20	Arkansas State	W	28-21	Sept. 26	at Arkansas State	4. Jordan Holmes, ATH	★★★★
Sept. 27	Middle Tennessee	W	24-16	Oct. 7	Jacksonville State	5. Jamarcus Harrison, QB	★★★★
Oct. 9	Louisiana Tech	W	35-7	Oct. 14	at Missouri State	6. Boogie Woods III, RB	★★★★
Oct. 21	at FIU	W	45-26	Oct. 21	Liberty	7. Anthony Carter, IOL	★★★★
Oct. 28	UTEP	W	33-20	Oct. 28	at Middle Tennessee	8. Mike Wallace Jr., IOL	★★★★
Nov. 8	at New Mexico State	W	24-21	Nov. 7	Delaware	9. Montra Sanford, EDGE	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Jacksonville State	L	26-35	Nov. 14	at Sam Houston	10. Jonathan Keys, DL	★★★★
Nov. 22	Missouri State	W	41-34	Nov. 21	FIU		
Nov. 29	at Liberty (ot)	W	48-42	Nov. 28	at WKU		
Dec. 5	at Jacksonville State #W		19-15				
Dec. 19	vs. W. Michigan %	L	6-41				
#CUSA Championship %Myrtle Beach Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Jerry Mack • Record at School: 10-4 (1 year)			
				Career Record: 41-19 (5 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Mitch Miliello			
				Defensive Coordinator: Marc Mattioli • Location: Kennesaw, Ga.			
				Stadium: Fifth Third Stadium (10,200)			

*Per Rivals

OFFENSE There's another quarterback battle on the Mountain as Liberty hopes to get back to the offensive explosiveness that it displayed in 2023. After a disappointing 2025 season, Ethan Vasko (151-of-266 passing, 1,961 yards, 10 TDs, 12 INTs) was sidelined throughout the spring following offseason shoulder surgery to repair an injury that plagued him throughout much of his first season. Liberty has brought in a pair of talented quarterbacks via the transfer portal in Deshawn Purdie (Wake Forest) and Jaylen Henderson (West Virginia), both of whom are battling for the job. The QB's top target figures to be Jamari Person, the Flames' leading returning receiver (28 catches, 315 yards in 2025).

Liberty's rushing attack led the nation in 2023 and ranked fourth nationally in 2024. Last season, the team's production dipped below 250 rushing yards per game (194.0) for the first time in head coach Jamey Chadwell's tenure at Liberty. Now, Chadwell and the Flames will have to sort through five incoming transfer running backs who will be running behind an offensive line that should be the early strength of the offense, returning four starters.

DEFENSE Shawn Quinn has arrived in Lynchburg as the team's new defensive coordinator, coming to Liberty from Virginia Tech, where he was Brent Pry's outside linebackers coach. Quinn will be looking to bring a toughness and physical mindset to a Flames' defense that ranked 10th out of 12 CUSA teams in rushing defense last season.

He gets to work with some key returning players in the front seven, led by linebacker Derrell Farrar, who paced the team with 71 tackles a season ago. Will this group be able to pressure the opposing quarterback? That's something that has plagued the Liberty defense the prior three seasons under Chadwell.

SPECIALISTS Liberty finds itself looking for new specialists, as placekicker Jay Billingsley and punter Max Morgan have exhausted their eligibility. Tyler Black was on the team last year after transferring from Wake Forest but lost the job in training camp. This season, he will have to compete with incoming Div. II McKendree transfer Chase Reeves. Reeves will also be competing at punter with Sam Crossan.

FINAL ANALYSIS Coming off a 4-8 season, the program's first losing campaign in 20 years, Chadwell made several changes to his coaching staff for the first time during his Liberty tenure. In addition to Quinn, the Flames have also hired Cory Peoples from Georgia Tech to help lead the secondary. Those changes, coupled with some enthusiasm behind the incoming transfer quarterbacks, give Liberty some optimism heading into this season.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 3-5 CUSA)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at Maine W 28-7	Sept. 5 at James Madison	1. Ellis Alloway, LB ***
Sept. 6 at Jacksonville State L 24-34	Sept. 12 Gardner-Webb	2. Tony Arnett, S ***
Sept. 13 at Bowling Green L 13-23	Sept. 19 Ball State	3. Jakobe Dejesus, WR ***
Sept. 20 James Madison L 13-31	Sept. 24 at Coastal Carolina	4. Macaiden Brown, S ***
Sept. 27 at Old Dominion L 7-21	Oct. 2 at Delaware	5. Jachin Davis, QB ***
Oct. 8 at UTEP W 19-8	Oct. 8 Sam Houston	6. Hunter Winn, IOL ***
Oct. 14 New Mexico State W 30-27	Oct. 21 at Kennesaw State	7. Austin Tremblay, IOL ***
Nov. 1 Delaware W 59-30	Oct. 31 FIU	8. Cam Wood, RB ***
Nov. 8 Missouri State L 17-21	Nov. 7 at New Mexico St.	9. Daniel Schiffert, IOL ***
Nov. 15 at FIU (ot) L 27-34	Nov. 14 Middle Tennessee	10. Malcolm Gaston, IOL ***
Nov. 22 at Louisiana Tech (ot) L 28-34	Nov. 21 WKU	
Nov. 29 Kennesaw State (ot) L 42-48	Nov. 28 at Missouri State	

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION	
Head Coach: Jamey Chadwell • Record at School: 25-13 (3 years) • Career Record: 123-70 (16 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Newland Isaac • Defensive Coordinator: Shawn Quinn • Location: Lynchburg, Va. • Stadium: Williams Stadium (25,000)	



JAMARI PERSON

SCOUTING THE FLAMES

"It all goes back to the quarterback. Had a lot of turnovers and a lot of system changes. Things like that. Their portal deal with their money situation, they've gotta take the right football guys that love ball. It's not so much an offensive deal. It's, are the players that they have truly invested in football? They're just not as tough as they were when that coaching staff first got in there. ... Are they getting guys for the right reasons? I think they found out the hard way last year that they were paying some guys that just wanted to get the money, collect a check and move on from there. We'll see how well they did this year from a character standpoint and just figuring out if they took the right guys that want to play football."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	3	Jamari Person (Sr.)	8	Nasir Newkirk (Fr.)
WR	2	Makai Jackson* (Sr.)	10	Jon Monteiro (So.)
WR	12	Rashawn Cunningham* (So.)	9	Bryce Randolph (Fr.)
LT	51	D.J. GETH (JR.)	52	Kevin Evehe* (So.)
LG	60	JOEP ENGBERS (JR.)	76	Gabe Smith (Fr.)
C	61	AARON FENIMORE (JR.)	62	Blake Martin (Fr.)
RG	53	Alex Birchmeier* (Jr.)	66	Erwil Anthony Jr. (Sr.)
RT	70	Austin Anderson (Jr.)	56	CHRISTIAN WILLIAMS (SR.)
TE	48	Caleb Ryan (Sr.)	87	LaKelsey Johnson Jr.* (Sr.)
QB	5	Deshawn Purdie* (Fr.)	13	Jaylen Henderson* (Sr.)
RB	7	Peyton Jones* (Jr.)	0	Jaylon Coleman (So.)

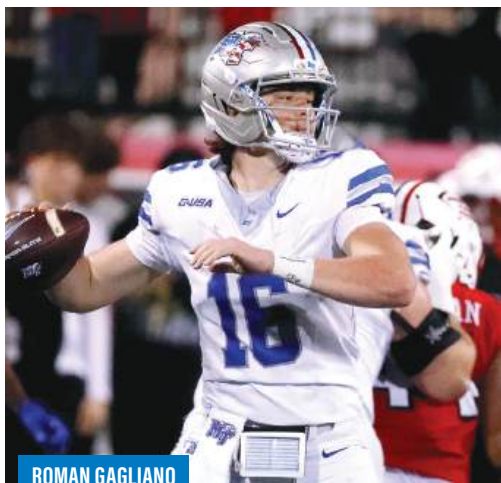
DEFENSE (3)

DE	18	AARON HESTER (SR.)	91	Michael Floyd* (So.)
DT	97	MIKE JARVIS (SR.)	88	Kam Cullins (So.)
DT	15	Markus Clark (Sr.)	56	Samuel Cohen (So.)
JOKER	8	Brenton Williams (Jr.)	11	Lorenzo Payne* (Jr.)
LB	1	DERRELL FARRAR (JR.)	30	Ethan Crisp (Jr.)
LB	33	Aidan Vaughan (Sr.)	6	Dillano Glaud (So.)
LB	4	Micah Pollard (Sr.)	9	Deuce Spurlock (Sr.)
CB	5	Elijah Hopkins (Sr.)	21	Ashton McShane* (So.)
CB	28	Jamal Miles (Jr.)	2	Jiquavious Marshall (So.)
S	0	D-Icey Hopkins* (Sr.)	17	Jayden Davis* (Jr.)
S	3	Ashton Whitner* (Sr.)	7	Izaiah Guy* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	98	Tyler Black (So.)	KR	10	Jon Monteiro (So.)
P	49	Sam Crossan (So.)	PR	0	Jaylon Coleman (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ROMAN GAGLIANO

SCOUTING THE BLUE RAIDERS

"Seems like they've had a lot of coaching changes on that staff. Like, they lost [offensive line coach] Kendall Simmons in the middle of the season. How are you gonna be consistent when you're losing coaches in-season? And they had a change with their offensive coordinator. I think Derek [Mason] is a really good coach, and a really good scheme guy, and I'm surprised that they haven't had success. ... They do have [quarterback Roman Gagliano] coming back. But it's gonna be tough because they've replaced both coordinators every year that Mason has been there. There's just so much turnover roster-wise and coaches-wise. They didn't get a ton of production guys in the portal. I don't feel very confident about them. That's for sure."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	6	AJ JONES (SR.)	1	Markus Allen* (Sr.)
WR	13	Cam'ron Lacy (Jr.)	7	Hogan Wasson* (Sr.)
WR	89	Landon Collins (So.)	19	Kason Stokes (So.)
LT	78	Kyle Larkin (Fr.)	53	Roman Jones (Fr.)
LG	61	Otto Janse Van Rensburg (So.)	57	Bo Bryan (Fr.)
C	71	Quentin Butler (Jr.)	76	Garrett Austin (Fr.)
RG	75	Reese Tripp* (Jr.)	63	Alex Gale (So.)
RT	77	Diego Blattler (Jr.)	62	Tim Jacobs* (Jr.)
TE	88	Tayvion Galloway* (So.)	39	Evan Poticher (Jr.)
QB	16	Roman Gagliano (So.)	18	Stanley Anderson-Lofton (Fr.)
RB	29	DJ Taylor (So.)	8	Antonio Martin Jr.* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	93	Aidan Butts (Jr.)	49	Tiyyan Robinson (So.)
NT	91	Felix Hixon (Sr.)	67	Archie Roseman V (Fr.)
DT	95	Zeion Simpson-Smith (So.)	90	Justin Bodford (So.)
EDGE	31	Mathias Malaki-Donaldson (Sr.)	17	Jayson Lowe (Jr.)
MLB	13	Ashton Taylor* (Sr.)	26	Korey Smith (Jr.)
WLB	46	REGGIE JOHNSON (SR.)	52	Micah Smith (Fr.)
CB	2	JACKSON LOWE (SO.)	15	Devan Carlisle (Jr.)
CB	12	Ricky Lee III* (Jr.)	24	Camari Hall (So.)
NB	23	KJ Miniefield (Jr.)	28	Alan Young (Jr.)
S	18	KALEN WOODS (SR.)	38	Locke Kennedy (So.)
S	10	Jordan Chestnut (Sr.)	7	Christopher Noble (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	91	Dominic Bourgeois* (Sr.)	KR	29	DJ Taylor (So.)
P	92	Ashton Logan (Sr.)	PR	29	DJ Taylor (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MIDDLE TENNESSEE BLUE RAIDERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 133 | CUSA PREDICTION: 9 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 2-6 CUSA

OFFENSE Middle Tennessee lost quarterback Nicholas Vattiato (2,150 passing yards, 16 TDs), who ranked third in Conference USA in passing efficiency at 122.9, to graduation. It's sophomore Roman Gagliano's job now after he passed for 1,005 yards and seven touchdowns in five games last season. Having some stability at quarterback is good news for the Blue Raiders, who are coming off consecutive three-win seasons.

First-year offensive coordinator Anthony Scelfo has very few returning skill players to work with. AJ Jones is the lone returning starter on offense. Running back Antonio Martin Jr. (Kansas State) is an experienced transfer portal addition to the backfield alongside DJ Taylor, who averaged 7.7 yards per carry last season (albeit on only 26 carries).

The offensive line must improve after the unit surrendered 30 sacks for 224 lost yards in 2025. Otto Janse Van Rensburg returns from injury up front.

DEFENSE There was some slight improvement for the MTSU defense last season, although the Blue Raiders still gave up 30.9 points and 399.3 yards per game. The run defense was a bright spot, finishing second in CUSA in allowing 143.1 rushing yards per game, compared to 197 yards the year prior.

Three returning starters on the defensive line helped bring those numbers down, but all three are now gone. Defensive tackle Zeion Simpson-Smith had three sacks and a fumble recovery as a freshman and is due for a bigger role.

Reggie Johnson leads all returning linebackers after tallying 34 tackles and 3.5 sacks. Jackson Lowe (four pass breakups last season) returns to a secondary that ranked 11th in the league in pass defense.

SPECIALISTS Dominic Bourgeois, a transfer from Div. III Susquehanna, is in line for placekicking duties. Ashton Logan returns at punter. He averaged 44.7 yards on 66 punts and downed 29 of them inside the opponent's 20-yard line in 2025. Taylor shared kickoff return duties last year, averaging 17.4 yards per return in that role.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Derek Mason finds himself in a potential make-or-break season in his third year at the helm of the Blue Raiders. MTSU ended its 2025 campaign on a positive note, winning its last two games with its two highest-scoring outputs of the season (31 points in both games), but the offense has to replace plenty of lost production while adjusting to five new offensive coaches. The defense was more physical last season, but it will have to replace its four leading tacklers and returns only 7.5 of its 23 sacks.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 2-6 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Austin Peay	L	14-34	Sept. 5	Murray State	1. Bryson Maddox, WR	★★★
Sept. 6	at Wisconsin	L	10-42	Sept. 12	at Marshall	2. Ethan Sherman, WR	★★★
Sept. 13	at Nevada	W	14-13	Sept. 19	Nevada	3. Bryce Williams, S	★★★
Sept. 20	Marshall	L	28-42	Sept. 26	at Jacksonville State	4. Rocco Williams, QB	★★★
Sept. 27	at Kennesaw State	L	16-24	Oct. 3	at Kansas	5. Robert Lathon Jr., RB	★★★
Oct. 8	Missouri State	L	20-22	Oct. 13	Delaware	6. Ziyon Butler, WR	★★★
Oct. 22	at Delaware	L	28-31	Oct. 20	at FIU	7. Shane Rochelle, LB	★★★
Oct. 29	Jacksonville State	L	21-24	Oct. 28	Kennesaw State	8. Ashley Walker, OT	★★★
Nov. 8	FIU	L	30-56	Nov. 7	WKU	9. Justis Haggard, S	★★★
Nov. 15	at WKU	L	26-42	Nov. 14	at Liberty	10. Jadin Hambrick, TE	★★★
Nov. 22	Sam Houston	W	31-17	Nov. 21	at Sam Houston		
Nov. 29	at New Mexico St. (ot)	W	31-24	Nov. 28	New Mexico State		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Derek Mason • Record at School: 6-18 (2 years) • Career Record: 33-73 (8+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Anthony Scelfo • Defensive Coordinator: Brian Stewart • Location: Murfreesboro, Tenn. • Stadium: Floyd Stadium (27,303)



MISSOURI STATE BEARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 128 | CUSA PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 5-3 CUSA

OFFENSE New Bears head coach Casey Woods will try to blend several key returners with transfers at quarterback and other key offensive spots. Quarterback transfers Henry Belin IV (Duke) and Skyler Locklear (UTEP) have experience and different skill sets, but Woods thinks either can effectively run the offense. “Both have got a chance,” Woods says. “We’ve got versatility in our offense to fit their strengths.”

The quarterbacks have options in the passing game as Jmariyae Robinson, who led Missouri State in receptions (44) and touchdown catches (seven) last fall, is back alongside key returnees James BlackStrain and Makai Cope and Tulsa transfer Mekhi Miller.

Missouri State also retained running back Ramone Green Jr., who will pair with Boise State transfer Jambres Dubar. Woods likes the tight end depth with Jeron Askren, Dillon Hipp and James Rexroat.

Offensive line depth is a concern, as the staff will need transfers such as Isaiah Villanueva and Sebastian Espinoza to contribute, along with returnees including Makhete Gueye and Logan Scrivner.

DEFENSE The unit has a centerpiece in linebacker Jared Lloyd, who tied for the team lead in tackles in 2025, and Woods likes the depth at edge. Transfers Kellen Lindstrom, Jalile Elliott and Josh Lukusa will complement Caden Wiest, who had two sacks last fall. Tim Brantley Jr. headlines the tackle group, which includes Iowa State transfer Markell Chapman. “If that depth develops like I think it can, we’ve got a chance to be pretty good on the defensive line,” Woods says.

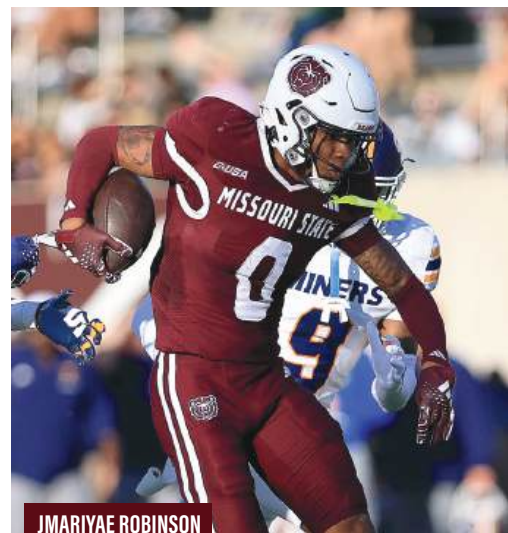
Lloyd leads a linebacker group also returning Cooper Roy, Austin Yelder, Jashawn Cooper and Martavis Blackmon. “He’s been a great off-season leader for us,” Woods says of Lloyd.

Safety projects well with Dylan Dixon and Christian Ford, who combined for 102 tackles last season, both returning. Missouri State went to the portal for two Joels — Kpassou and Boamah — at cornerback.

SPECIALISTS Kicker Yousef Obeid, who earned honorable mention All-Conference USA honors last season, and primary punter Stewart McDonald are both back. Robinson shared kickoff return duties in 2025 and averaged 19.4 yards per return.

FINAL ANALYSIS There’s significant turnover on both lines, but if the offensive front can protect Belin or Locklear, there should be playmaking opportunities with the wideout and tight end depth. Missouri State has trips to Texas A&M and SMU before beginning Conference USA play. “I’m really excited for them to get in front of that,” Woods says. “It will be a great measuring stick.”

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 5-3 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at USC	L	13-73	Sept. 5	at Texas A&M	1. Jedrick Russell Jr., LB	★★★
Sept. 6	at Marshall	W	21-20	Sept. 12	Lindenwood	2. Maurice Jones Jr., LB	★★★
Sept. 13	SMU	L	10-28	Sept. 19	Marshall	3. Josiah Turner, S	★★★
Sept. 20	Tennessee-Martin	W	42-10	Sept. 26	at SMU	4. Chase Mideau, DL	★★★
Sept. 27	WKU	L	22-27	Oct. 8	at WKU	5. Deion Thomas, ATH	★★★
Oct. 8	at Middle Tennessee	W	22-20	Oct. 14	Kennesaw State	6. Brett Ottensmeyer, QB	★★★
Oct. 22	at New Mexico St. (ot)	W	24-17	Oct. 20	at Delaware	7. Amar’e Johnson, RB	★★★
Oct. 29	FIU	W	28-21	Oct. 27	Sam Houston	8. Jerrick Martin, WR	★★★
Nov. 8	at Liberty	W	21-17	Nov. 7	at FIU	9. Brandon Hightower, DL	★★★
Nov. 15	UTEP	W	38-24	Nov. 14	New Mexico State	10. Santiago Castillo, IOL	★★★
Nov. 22	at Kennesaw State	L	34-41	Nov. 21	at Jacksonville State		
Nov. 29	Louisiana Tech	L	30-42	Nov. 28	Liberty		*Per Rivals
Dec. 18	vs. Arkansas State #	L	28-34				
#Xbox Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Casey Woods • Record at School: First Season			
				Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinator: Mark Cala			
				Defensive Coordinator: Jack Curtis • Location: Springfield, Mo.			
				Stadium: Robert W. Plaster Stadium (17,500)			



JMARIYAE ROBINSON

SCOUTING THE BEARS

“Offensively, they’ll change a little bit with that new staff. It’s just tough for them because they got there late when the portal opened, so they were kind of scrambling to try and take some guys. ... They took [UTEP transfer quarterback] Skyler Locklear, so that’ll be interesting. I think they’ll be different, but I also think that they got some good coaches who are gonna scheme ‘em up, put them in the right situations like [new head coach Casey Woods] did at SMU. To me, that one is a little different from a player standpoint. They may not be the most talented, but I think that they’re gonna be very, very well-coached.”

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	0	JMARIYAE ROBINSON (SR.)	81	AJ Bell Jr. (Fr.)
WR	5	James BlackStrain (Sr.)	83	Amare Whetsell (Fr.)
WR	11	Makai Cope (Sr.)	6	Mekhi Miller* (Sr.)
LT	77	Sebastian Espinoza* (Jr.)	66	Makhete Gueye (Sr.)
LG	71	King Large* (Fr.)	67	Ben Liedtke (Jr.)
C	72	Isaiah Villanueva* (Sr.)	75	Logan Scrivner (So.)
RG	75	Logan Scrivner (So.)	52	Isaiah Villanueva* (Sr.)
RT	54	Matthew Greene (Jr.)		William Dixon* (Sr.)
TE	88	JERON ASKREN (SO.)	85	Dillon Hipp (So.)
QB	2	Henry Belin IV* (Sr.)	9	Skyler Locklear* (Sr.)
RB	22	Ramone Green Jr. (Jr.)	1	Breezy Dubar* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	5	Kellen Lindstrom* (So.)	92	Josh Lukusa* (Sr.)
DT	11	Tim Brantley Jr. (Jr.)	52	Kaden Jones* (Jr.)
DT	99	Markell Chapman* (Jr.)	44	Malachi Madison* (Sr.)
DE	30	Caden Wiest (Jr.)	10	Jalile Elliott* (So.)
LB	31	Cooper Roy (Jr.)	15	Martavis Blackmon (Jr.)
LB	0	JARED LLOYD (SR.)	38	Stratton Shufelt* (Jr.)
LB	35	Austin Yelder (Jr.)	21	Jashawn Cooper (So.)
CB	8	Joel Kpassou* (Sr.)	20	Floyd Williams (Jr.)
CB	12	Joel Boamah* (Jr.)	26	Darryon Taylor (Sr.)
S	9	DYLAN DIXSON (SR.)	16	J.J. O’NEAL (SR.)
S	29	CHRISTIAN FORD (JR.)	18	Geo Jallah* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	36	Yousef Obeid (Jr.)	KR	0	Jmariyae Robinson (Sr.)
P	25	Stewart McDonald (So.)	PR	8	Joel Kpassou* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

MICHAEL GULLEDGE/SPECIAL TO THE NEWS-LEADER



TK KING

SCOUTING THE AGGIES

"I know that they really hang their hat on being a juco-centric team. Last year, I bet over 50% of their roster was juco guys. I'm not necessarily saying that's a bad thing, but I do think that you've gotta have a fine balance when it comes to that. ... The quarterback situation is another piece to it. Since they lost Diego Pavia [to Vanderbilt in 2024], they've been trying to find another guy who can do those things, but that dude is always hard to replace. But yeah, they're just heavy on juco guys that you know, for whatever reason, haven't been able to pan out for them."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	11	AJ Williams III (Jr.)	6	Brodie Malone-Bradford (So.)
WR	1	TK KING (SR.)	7	TJ Pride (Jr.)
WR	5	Myles Libman* (Jr.)	9	Terrione Graves (Jr.)
LT	55	Ma'Kyri Lee (Sr.)	77	Gavin Jones (Fr.)
LG	69	James Williams* (Jr.)	50	Luke Moise* (Jr.)
C	56	Mark Chapman* (Sr.)	58	Sioeli Helu (Sr.)
RG	70	MATEO RODRIGUEZ (SO.)	78	Armond Owens* (Jr.)
RT	54	Tyler Keinath* (Sr.)	71	Evan Blaettler (Jr.)
TE	18	Joshua Goines (Jr.)	88	Carson Su'esu'e* (Fr.)
QB	3	Trey Hedden* (Jr.)	14	Adam Damante (Jr.)
RB	2	James Jones* (Sr.)	8	DIJON STANLEY (SR.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	16	GABE PETERSON (SR.)	15	Obinna Okeke (Jr.)
DT	97	Henry Davis III (Sr.)	95	Josiah Jackson (Sr.)
DT	44	Enzo-Pierre Tayou (Sr.)	13	Kaia Roberts-Day* (Sr.)
DE	21	Zhakius Thomas* (Jr.)	8	Brad Vislisle (Jr.)
MLB	14	SONE AUPIU (SR.)	10	Chance Barron (Jr.)
WLB	6	TORY GETHERS (SR.)	34	Zaiden Davis (So.)
CB	4	De'Marcus Peters* (Sr.)	0	Lorenzo Smith (Sr.)
CB	1	JOSHIAH CHARLES (SR.)	12	Amaurey Brooks* (So.)
NB	3	Tayden Barnes* (Jr.)	7	Saveon Freeman (Jr.)
S	5	NICK SESSION (SR.)	20	DJ Cloyd (Sr.)
S	9	Bernock Iya (Sr.)	22	RJ Chapman* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	17	Ilya Uvaydov* (Sr.)	KR	8	Dijon Stanley (Sr.)
P	91	Brody Richter* (Sr.)	PR	1	TK King (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NEW MEXICO STATE AGGIES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 129 | CUSA PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-6 CUSA

OFFENSE New Mexico State improved in 2025, but the Aggies still struggled to produce consistent offense, finishing 113th nationally in yards per game. To address that deficiency, they're turning to junior transfer quarterback Trey Hedden from FCS Furman. Hedden inherits a receiving group with vertical threats, including TK King, who totaled 588 receiving yards and three touchdowns last season after missing time early with an injury. The return of AJ Williams III adds intrigue after he missed 2025 due to injury following his transfer from Div. III Mary Hardin-Baylor.

Protection and line play were also concerns. New Mexico State allowed nearly three sacks per game in 2025, prompting the staff to bring in multiple experienced offensive linemen through the transfer portal to reinforce the unit and improve both pass protection and physicality.

The biggest issue last season came on the ground. The Aggies tied for last in the FBS at just 2.6 yards per carry, often leaving the offense one-dimensional. FCS Delaware State transfer James Jones and Iowa transfer TJ Washington Jr. join returning starter Dijon Stanley, and even modest improvement in the run game should open up the passing attack and provide needed balance.

DEFENSE New Mexico State forced 24 turnovers last season — nine fumbles and 15 interceptions — which tied for 14th nationally. That ability to create extra possessions helped keep the Aggies competitive.

While the Aggies do lose some pieces, there is reason to believe this unit can remain reliable. Tayden Barnes returns after starting all 12 games in 2024 before transferring to Cincinnati in 2025, and he brings versatility across the secondary, capable of lining up at nickel or either safety spot. He'll be part of a secondary that also features Nick Session.

At linebacker, the Aggies return the duo of Tory Gethers and Sone Aupiu. Gethers recorded 88 total tackles, three sacks and one forced fumble, while Aupiu added 68 tackles, one sack, two forced fumbles and an interception in 11 games.

SPECIALISTS The kicking game will feature competition at placekicker, while Minnesota transfer Brody Richter appears set to handle punting duties. The return game could be a strength, with King and Stanley both capable of flipping field position.

FINAL ANALYSIS New Mexico State has brought in fresh faces in an effort to return to bowl eligibility. Head coach Tony Sanchez enters his third season after two years of growing pains. With a favorable schedule and key transfers in place, a path to six wins is there if the offense finds balance and the defense limits explosive plays.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-6 CUSA)

Aug. 30	Bryant	W	19-3
Sept. 6	Tulsa	W	21-14
Sept. 13	at Louisiana Tech	L	14-49
Sept. 27	at New Mexico	L	20-38
Oct. 2	Sam Houston	W	37-10
Oct. 14	at Liberty	L	27-30
Oct. 22	Missouri State (ot)	L	17-24
Nov. 1	at WKU	L	16-35
Nov. 8	Kennesaw State	L	21-24
Nov. 15	at Tennessee	L	9-42
Nov. 22	at UTEP	W	34-31
Nov. 29	Middle Tennessee (ot) L	24-31	

2026 SCHEDULE

Aug. 29	at Florida State
Sept. 5	Mercyhurst
Sept. 12	at Hawai'i
Sept. 26	New Mexico
Oct. 1	WKU
Oct. 7	at FIU
Oct. 21	at Sam Houston
Oct. 28	Jacksonville State
Nov. 7	Liberty
Nov. 14	at Missouri State
Nov. 21	Delaware
Nov. 28	at Middle Tennessee

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. JaDarius Sanders, WR	★★★
2. Xavier Rucker, RB	★★★
3. Jamaun Thompson, EDGE	★★★
4. Caleb Pyfrom, IOL	★★★
5. Garrett Stennett, S	★★★
6. Jaylyn Manning, LB	★★★
7. Eric Rivera, S	★★★
8. Faapaia Fualema, LB	★★★
9. Isaiah Garcia Perez, IOL	★★★
10. Kalani Mcleod, QB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Tony Sanchez • Record at School: 7-17 (2 years) • Career Record: 27-57 (7 years) • Offensive Coordinator: David Yost • Defensive Coordinator: Joe Morris • Location: Las Cruces, N.M. • Stadium: Aggie Memorial Stadium (28,853)



SAM HOUSTON BEARKATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 137 | CUSA PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 2-10, 1-7 CUSA

OFFENSE There are reasons to be optimistic about this offense in Year 2 of the Phil Longo era. The Bearkats will enter the 2026 campaign with a QB1 in place, as Landyn Locke has solidified his hold on the job after playing in six games for the Kats last year, completing 71 of his 141 attempts for 765 yards and four touchdowns.

Luckily, the Kats will have a lot of weapons returning who will have spent an entire spring, summer and fall camp working with a single starting quarterback and not a rotation. Senior wideout Chris Reed gives Locke a dependable target. Reed played in all 12 games and led the Bearkats with 460 receiving yards and five touchdowns.

In the backfield, Landan "Coco" Brown and Alton McCaskill return after combining for 858 rushing yards.

The biggest concern for this unit: rebuilding an offensive line that lost every starter either to graduation or to the transfer portal.

DEFENSE This marks the second season under defensive coordinator Freddie Aughtry-Lindsay, and the Kats are hoping that they can muster some improvement after ranking last in CUSA in total defense last season, allowing 483.5 yards per game. This will be the first year that Aughtry-Lindsay will have had a full offseason to recruit his own players and hire his own staff, but for a team that surrendered 37.8 points per game, every move will need to yield positive results.

Defensive tackle Dylan Frazier provides a nice building block after posting 41 tackles, four tackles for a loss and two sacks. Some Power 4 transfers — Josh Alexander-Felton (NC State), Stacy Bey (Arizona) and Jace Arnold (Wisconsin) — should slide into the starting lineup after seeing limited time at their former schools.

SPECIALISTS It seems that the placekicking job will belong to either transfer Sam Carpenter or Tate Ryan. Carpenter went 1-of-3 on field goals at Pitt last season, while Ryan took a redshirt at Sam Houston. Punting duties will fall to transfer Cal Joseph, who averaged 38.1 yards per punt at Wake Forest last year.

FINAL ANALYSIS It's only his second season in charge, but this is looking like a make-or-break year for Longo. A year after getting 10 wins and a New Orleans Bowl victory in 2024, the Bearkats struggled to only two wins in Longo's debut. Things could shift in the staff's favor, though, as the team returns to play in refurbished Elliott T. Bowers Stadium after playing every game away from campus. Of course, that also removes any excuses for another disastrous campaign.

2025 RESULTS (2-10, 1-7 CUSA)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	at WKU	L 24-41	Sept. 5	at Troy	1. Jaylon Jones, S	★★★
Aug. 29	UNLV	L 21-38	Sept. 12	Tulsa	2. Jack Merryman, TE	★★★
Sept. 6	at Hawai'i	L 20-37	Sept. 19	Nicholls	3. Jabaric Sullivan, CB	★★★
Sept. 20	at Texas	L 0-55	Sept. 26	at Texas Tech	4. Uzziah Warmate, DL	★★★
Oct. 2	at New Mexico State	L 10-37	Oct. 8	at Liberty	5. CJ June, CB	★★★
Oct. 9	Jacksonville State	L 27-29	Oct. 14	WKU	6. Robert McFarland, S	★★★
Oct. 15	UTEP	L 17-35	Oct. 21	New Mexico State	7. Myles Joseph, IDL	★★★
Oct. 31	at Louisiana Tech	L 14-55	Oct. 27	at Missouri State	8. Demetrius Dowdy, RB	★★★
Nov. 8	at Oregon State	W 21-17	Nov. 7	at Jacksonville State	9. Kaden Winkfield, RB	★★★
Nov. 15	Delaware	W 26-23	Nov. 14	Kennesaw State	10. Brett Holloway, QB	★★★
Nov. 22	at Middle Tennessee	L 17-31	Nov. 21	Middle Tennessee		
Nov. 29	FIU	L 16-56	Nov. 28	at FIU		*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION						
Head Coach: Phil Longo • Record at School: 2-10 (1 year) • Career Record: 9-24 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Zack Patterson • Defensive Coordinator: Freddie Aughtry-Lindsay • Location: Huntsville, Texas • Stadium: Elliott T. Bowers Stadium (14,000)						



LANDYN LOCKE

SCOUTING THE BEARKATS

"I think they can turn things around in Year 2 under [head coach] Phil Longo. What they do offensively is really good. They just didn't have a quarterback last year that could run what they were trying to run. Hunter Watson was really damn good, but what they were asking him to do wasn't what he did well. But scheme-wise, and even the guys that they brought in with a short amount of time, were solid players. It's just tough if you don't have a quarterback who fits what you're trying to do. ... They lost a lot of pretty good players, but they ended up signing some dudes that should be able to come in and help right away. I do think that they will be a lot better than what they were last year."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	2	CHRIS REED (SR.)	5	Kyan Berry-Johnson* (So.)
WR	12	Kamari Maxwell* (So.)	18	Christian Zachary* (So.)
WR	7	Grady O'Neill (Sr.)	3	TIM BURNS JR. (SR.)
LT	58	Carter Kadow* (Jr.)	76	Nathan McClelland* (Jr.)
LG	74	Graceson Spann (So.)	75	Elijah Collins* (Jr.)
C	54	Brock Stukes* (Jr.)	60	Cam Todd (Sr.)
RG	71	Denell Nix Jr.* (So.)	57	Zo'Maryon Bryan (Sr.)
RT	67	Isaac Sohn (Jr.)	63	Joe Warren* (Jr.)
TE	87	Max Whisner* (Sr.)	84	London Deyon (So.)
QB	8	Landyn Locke (So.)	15	DJ Bailey (So.)
RB	34	Landan "Coco" Brown (Jr.)	22	Alton McCaskill (Sr.)

DEFENSE (1)

DE	15	Josh Alexander-Felton* (So.)	48	Chauncey Chidi (Sr.)
DT	97	DYLAN FRAZIER (SR.)	95	She'Fon Boyd (Jr.)
DT	92	Jarra Anderson* (Jr.)	98	Justin Terrell* (So.)
LB	21	Dean Ford (So.)	33	Brian Bates Jr.* (Jr.)
LB	26	Tokyo Gordon (Sr.)	23	Mike King Jr.* (So.)
LB	18	Stacy Bey* (So.)	12	Elijah Groves* (Fr.)
STRIKER	9	Jace Arnold* (Jr.)	0	William Davis* (Sr.)
CB	5	Jalyn Stanford (Jr.)	3	Joey Hunter* (Sr.)
CB	20	Dravon Wilson (So.)	7	Caesar Magee III* (Sr.)
S	13	Tyler Bailey (Sr.)	29	Lyric Smith (So.)
S	40	Railyn Adams (So.)	6	Jaylon Jones* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	94	Sam Carpenter* (Jr.)	KR	3	Tim Burns Jr. (Sr.)
P	31	Cal Joseph* (So.)	PR	3	Tim Burns Jr. (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



RODNEY TISDALE JR.

SCOUTING THE HILLTOPPERS

"[Head coach] Tyson Helton drives that thing. He's a super-smart dude who has a great pulse for his program. They're always going to win because of him. I've got a lot of respect for him and what they do. He's a darn good football coach. He's fallen in love with that part of the country. That's why you don't see him jumping at all of those little flashes in the pan like some people do. ... Eventually, in this business, you get a call that you can't turn down, so if he gets that, who knows? But he's got job security there, which is hard to come by. They love him there. It's hard to leave a place where the structure is built and they're always going to win 8-9 games, even with a revolving door at OC, because of the consistency at the top."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	2	K.D. HUTCHINSON (SR.)	4	Cameron Flowers (So.)
WR	12	Quincy Burroughs (Sr.)	17	Zion Taylor* (Jr.)
WR	21	Nigel Johnson* (Sr.)	84	Jeremiah Carroll* (Sr.)
LT	67	Tai Ray* (Jr.)	64	Jackson Dials (Fr.)
LG	70	Rhett Larson* (Sr.)	73	Nonso Omezi* (Sr.)
C	50	Alec Johnson* (Sr.)	52	Isiah Stoudemire (Fr.)
RG	51	Roq Montgomery* (Jr.)	76	Max Thurston (So.)
RT	74	KARSTEN UPCHURCH (SR.)	59	Alex Lopez* (Fr.)
TE	20	CC Ezirim* (Sr.)	87	Coleson Arends* (Jr.)
QB	16	RODNEY TISDALE JR. (SO.)	11	Brock Glenn* (Jr.)
RB	3	Ajay Allen* (Sr.)	9	Kalib Hicks* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	50	Elin Jones (Sr.)	48	Zsacari Minnis (So.)
DT	99	Eric Etienne (So.)	54	Sekou Peters (Fr.)
DT	52	Jakeem Fletcher (Sr.)	92	Javin Griffin* (Sr.)
DE	55	Venson Sneed (Sr.)	98	Nathan Gonzales* (Sr.)
LB	22	Jordan Donald (So.)	18	Geajorm Akpaloo* (Jr.)
LB	20	Zach Smith (So.)	15	Garrison Madden* (Sr.)
CB	14	Braxton Myers (Jr.)	27	Jordan Bergeron (Fr.)
CB	21	Tony Newsome Jr.* (Sr.)	24	Lataj Wright (Sr.)
NB	10	Christian White* (Sr.)	37	Justin Brown (So.)
S	7	JAYLEN LEWIS (SR.)	19	Jacob Cosby-Mosley* (So.)
S	17	DAVE HERARD (SR.)	12	BJ Carey* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	58	Michael Buck (So.)	KR	4	Cameron Flowers (So.)
P	35	Daniel Wall (Fr.)	PR	2	K.D. Hutchinson (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



WKU HILLTOPPERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 89 | CUSA PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 CUSA

OFFENSE Under head coach Tyson Helton, entering his eighth season, the Hilltoppers have become accustomed to learning a new playbook on a near yearly basis, with no offensive coordinator staying for more than two years. Now it's Bodie Reeder's turn to work with the offensive-minded Helton to keep the Tops among CUSA's best passing offenses. Reeder spent the past two seasons at Middle Tennessee, and last season, the Blue Raiders averaged 266.1 passing yards per game, fourth in CUSA.

The Tops likely have a quarterback battle brewing between sophomore Rodney Tisdale Jr. and Florida State transfer Brock Glenn. Tisdale took over starting duties at midseason and performed well, passing for 1,432 yards and nine TDs in nine games, but he lacks Glenn's game experience.

Graduation and portal losses hit hard, but versatile senior K.D.

Hutchinson (team-high 66 catches for 618 yards, three TDs) is a proven returning talent, and the Tops had no trouble attracting promising transfers at the skill positions, including running back Ajay Allen (Tulsa and Nebraska), wide receiver Nigel Johnson (FCS South Carolina State) and tight end CC Ezirim (Toledo). The offensive line is almost a complete rebuild, with right tackle Karsten Upchurch the only returning starter.

DEFENSE Last year, the Tops allowed 22.8 points per game (second in CUSA) despite giving up 400.8 yards per game (seventh in CUSA). WKU was particularly strong in the red zone, surrendering touchdowns only 34.7% of the time, the nation's best mark.

Redshirt senior Jaylen Lewis emerged as an impact player at safety (74 tackles, team-high three interceptions) and joins fellow returning starter Dave Herard to form a tough combo. Defensive end Venson Sneed and defensive tackle Jakeem Fletcher return to provide some stability on the defensive front, which lost standout Harper Holloman in the portal to West Virginia. The Tops are thin on experience at linebacker — leading tacklers Jaylen Wester and Anthony Brackenridge both exhausted their eligibility, while Koron Hayward transferred to TCU and Miller Malone went to Houston. Fall camp will feature plenty of competition for jobs.

SPECIALISTS Australian punter Daniel Wall, a freshman, looked strong in the spring, while sophomore Michael Buck likely gets first shot at place-kicking. Hutchinson is a dangerous option to return punts, with redshirt sophomore Cameron Flowers back to handle kickoff returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS The early schedule is brutal, and the Tops will have to navigate that stretch and maintain cohesion to contend for a CUSA title again. At the least, expect WKU to extend its bowl streak to eight straight under CUSA's longest-tenured current head coach.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	Sam Houston	W	41-24	Sept. 5	at Nevada	1. Makhii Brazier, LB	★★★
Aug. 30	North Alabama	W	55-6	Sept. 12	at Georgia	2. Ceelaj Embry, DL	★★★
Sept. 6	at Toledo	L	21-45	Sept. 19	at Indiana	3. Cam O'Hara, QB	★★★
Sept. 20	Nevada	W	31-16	Sept. 26	Mercyhurst	4. La'Kamren Meadows, RB	★★★
Sept. 27	at Missouri State	W	27-22	Oct. 1	at New Mexico State	5. Jaylen Pollard, S	★★★
Oct. 3	at Delaware	W	27-24	Oct. 8	Missouri State	6. Zayden Walters, IOL	★★★
Oct. 14	FIU	L	6-25	Oct. 14	at Sam Houston	7. Westen Ard, LB	★★★
Oct. 21	at Louisiana Tech (ot)	W	28-27	Oct. 27	Delaware	8. Tre'von McGory, WR	★★★
Nov. 1	New Mexico State	W	35-16	Nov. 7	at Middle Tennessee	9. Asa Holbert, OT	★★★
Nov. 15	Middle Tennessee	W	42-26	Nov. 14	Jacksonville State	10. Bryce Fulda, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 22	at LSU	L	10-13	Nov. 21	at Liberty		
Nov. 29	at Jacksonville State	L	34-37	Nov. 28	Kennesaw State		*Per Rivals
Dec. 23	vs. Southern Miss	W	27-16				
#New Orleans Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Tyson Helton • Record at School: 57-36 (7 years)			
				Career Record: 57-36 (7 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Bodie Reeder, Joe Bernardi • Defensive Coordinator: Davis Merritt • Location: Bowling Green, Ky.			
				Stadium: Houchens Industries-L. T. Smith Stadium (19,250)			